

Basic Windows Hardening Checklist

Account Setup

Force Accounts to Have Passwords

- Open the “Run” app by searching for it or using Win+ r.
- Type **netplwiz** into the dialog box and click “OK”.
- Check the box labeled “Users must enter a user name and password to use this computer.” in the “User Accounts” window.

Limit Administrator Privileges to only Necessary Accounts

- From the same “User Accounts” window, you can set whether or not accounts have administrator privileges.
- Select an account that you want to add or remove administrator privileges from, then click “Properties”.
- In the new window, switch to the “Group Membership” tab, and select “Standard User” or “Administrator” as appropriate.

Require Log In on Screensaver

- Open the “Settings” app.
- Go to the “Accounts” section.
- Go to the “Sign-in options” section in the sidebar.
- Under the “Require sign-in” header, select “When PC wakes up from sleep”

Windows Security Features

Turn on Windows Firewall

- Open the “Windows Security” app.
- Go to “Firewall & network protection”.
- Ensure that the domain, private, and public networks all have their firewall enabled.

Turn on Windows’ [Built-In Antivirus](#)

This serves the same general purpose as 3rd-party antivirus software, providing scans and real-time protection against malicious software.

- Open the “Windows Security” app.
- Go to “Virus & threat protection”.
- Go to “Virus & threat protection settings”.
- Turn on “Real-time protection”, “Cloud-delivered protection”, “Automatic sample submission”, and “Tamper Protection”.

Disable Remote Access

- Open the “Control Panel” app.
- Go to “System and Security” (You may need to change the view settings to “view by category”).
- Go to “System”.
- Go to “Remote settings”
- Under the “Remote” tab, uncheck the “Allow Remote Assistance connections to this computer” box.
- Depending on your version of Windows, there may be another similar feature you need to disable:
 - Open the “Settings” app.
 - Go to “System”.
 - Go to “Remote Desktop”.

If your version of windows has the remote desktop feature, turn it off.

Allow Automatic Microsoft Software Updates

- Open the “Settings” app.
- Go to “Update & Security”.
- Go to “Advanced Options”.
- Turn “Receive updates for other Microsoft products when you update Windows” on.

Advanced Windows Hardening Techniques

- Uninstall Unused Programs
- Encryption
- Backups